KEEPING AN EYE

The TMC national general secretary is raising his profile at a time when central agencies are after him for alleged scams

- Central investigating agencies have questioned Abhishek on five occasions
- Over the past year, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has interrogated him twice, in Delhi and in Kolkata, over the coal scam; wife Rujira Banerjee, sister-in-law Maneka Gambhir also questioned multiple times
- Questioned by ED in the alleged teachers' recruitment scam case in Kolkata on Sept. 13 when he was to attend the INDIA coordination committee meeting; parents Amit and Lata Banerjee also summoned
- In supplementary chargesheet on the recruitment scam, ED has named Abhishek, alleging that one of the accused they have arrested, Sujay Krishna Bhadra, was close to the TMC heir

vant eye on proceedings from Kolkata, Abhishek did the honours at Rajghat, the chosen venue for the October 2-3 protests, along with a voluble posse of party MPs, MLAs as well as zilla parishad and panchayat samiti chiefs. Because the frozen funds related to the high-profile Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Grameen and suchlike, they sought an appointment with Sadhvi Niranjan Jyoti, the Union minister of state for rural development, at Krishi Bhavan. Denied an audience, they duly went on to enact all the sacred rituals of agitprop.

Immediately after he was released on October 3 night, the script dictated that the circus would roll back to its home town—where the show would of course go on. The Diamond Harbour MP announced a march to Raj Bhawan the day after, with the idea of formally apprising Bengal governor C.V. Ananda Bose about the grievances regarding funds. On October 5, the streets of Kolkata stood choked as thousands poured in from across the state to participate in the march. But Bose was in north Bengal, so Abhishek chose the seemingly impromptu move of sitting on an indefinite dharna—which finally lasted five days till October 9—in front of Raj Bhawan. In short, a series of public performances that allowed Abhishek to play the decisive leader and counter the Opposition's allegation—especially from BJP strongman Suvendu Adhikari, a TMC turncoat himself—that Mamata's nephew is a mere 'parachute leader'. An unjust characterisation, for Abhishek takes much of the credit for the TMC's stupendous victory in the 2021 assembly polls. Anyway, he had demonstrated that he could amass thousands of people on Kolkata's streets on a day's notice.

The Delhi protests and its sequels are a follow-up of Abhishek's Nabo Jowar (New Wave) Yatra in April ahead of the Bengal panchayat polls, where he had first raised the pitch on the issue of central funds. Launched on April 25, the campaign lasted around two months, with the TMC leader travelling from Coochbehar in the north to Kakdwip in the south. During the yatra, Abhishek received numerous complaints from people who had stopped receiving their NREGS dues. Beneficiaries of PMAY-G also reached out to him. "We realised that most people held the state government responsible for the default," says a TMC leader. "It was then that Abhishek decided that we needed to turn the tables on the BJP on the issue."

MANY TMC LEADERS BELIEVE THE PARTY IS PROJECTING ABHISHEK AS ITS NATIONAL FACE AHEAD OF THE 2024 LOK SABHA ELECTION

Political analysts also point to a significant change in the current agitation—the active part taken by senior leaders Kalyan Banerjee and Kolkata mayor and state minister Firhad Hakim. Hakim even heaped praise on Abhishek for his tenacity in a speech on October 9. Prima facie, it's natural for senior leaders to work closely with Abhishek, but the fact remains that till a few months back, party old-timers close to Mamata like Banerjee and Hakim had resisted Abhishek's ascension in the party, and not been coy about dropping public hints to that effect. According to TMC sources, the "falling in line" of leaders unhappy with the gradual increase of Abhishek's clout has been a "natural progression"—he's now seen as second only to Mamata beyond anyone's reasonable doubt. "He has proved himself as a worthy successor to Didi by strategising and winning the 2021 polls. Then he won the panchayat polls. What option do old-timers have?" asks a leader. Significantly, ever since the start of the protest campaign on October 2, Mamata has largely been silent, except taking to X (formerly Twitter) to protest the brief detention of TMC leaders.

That the BJP, too, cannot ignore the content of Abhishek's spirited offensive is proved by their all-out effort to refute the TMC's damaging allegations of "political vendetta" and "economic blockade". Sadhvi Jyoti, with whom Abhishek and his team could not secure an audience in Delhi, flew down to Kolkata on October 7. In a press conference, she denied that she intentionally didn't meet the TMC delegation and listed out the monetary assistance the Modi government has provided Bengal since 2014. Even on October 2, Bengal BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar, Union minister of state for education Subhas Sarkar and BJP MPs from Bengal Locket Chatterjee and Jyotirmoy Singh Mahato were summoned to the capital to counter the TMC's charges. Giriraj Singh, the Union minister for rural development and panchayati raj, too, did his bit from his constituency, Begusarai in Bihar, demanding a CBI investigation into the allegation that the TMC-led state administration had siphoned off